China has ~12% of global AI-relevant compute

LAST UPDATED 2026-09-06

Geopolitics

Read the evidence ↓

> *China has managed to maintain about 12% of the world's AI-relevant compute.*

At a glance

- **Assessment:** Emerging
- **Confidence in assessment:** 55%
- **Predicted timing:** Mid 2026
- **Primary source:** ai-2027.com, Mid 2026: China Wakes Up

What AI 2027 Predicted

The scenario states that by mid-2026, China has "managed to maintain about 12% of the world's AI-relevant compute" despite US chip export controls. This is presented in the context of China partially offsetting export restrictions through domestic chip production (Huawei Ascend), stockpiling, and smuggling, while still falling significantly behind the US in aggregate compute capacity.

How We Track This

We monitor:

- Epoch AI's GPU cluster and AI supercomputer datasets
- CSET (Georgetown) estimates of Chinese AI compute capacity
- SemiAnalysis reports on global GPU deployment
- Huawei Ascend production volume estimates
- Industry analysts tracking chip smuggling and stockpile estimates

Current Evidence

Epoch AI Data: Epoch AI's AI Supercomputers dataset (covering roughly 10–20% of total global AI computing capacity) shows the US hosting the majority of GPU cluster performance, followed by China. While this dataset undersamples the full picture, it provides the best available comparative baseline.

- AI Supercomputer Performance Share by Country — Epoch AI

- Trends in AI Supercomputers — Epoch AI

Tracked cluster share: Epoch's country comparison lists China at 14.1% of represented performance. This is a geographically located, publicly tracked cluster measure, not a census of all Chinese-controlled AI compute. It provides context without resolving the original share. Epoch

- State of Global AI Compute 2025 Edition — GeoCoded

Historical compute goal: The cited 2025 policy goal was 300 EFLOPS of aggregate computing power with an AI component. A target does not establish deployment or its share of a comparable global total.

- US and China AI Infrastructure 2025 — AI Hive

Private Sector Dominance: Epoch AI notes that industry's share of global AI compute surged from 40% in 2019 to 80% in 2025. Since US hyperscalers dominate the private sector, this trend may further concentrate compute in the US.

SemiAnalysis deployment-flow estimate (August 2026): Dylan Patel of SemiAnalysis estimated that about 70% of newly deployed AI data-center watts are currently going to the United States and less than 10% to China. This is a specialist analyst estimate based on proprietary industry tracking, not a publicly reproducible census. It measures the flow of new power capacity rather than China's share of the installed global compute stock, and watts do not adjust for differences in chip efficiency. The estimate therefore suggests downward pressure on China's global share without establishing that the tracked stock is already below 10%.

- Dylan Patel interview: Anthropic and OpenAI will have most of the world's compute by 2028

Counterevidence & Limitations

- Available data captures only a fraction of global AI compute. Undisclosed military and commercial installations can create unequal coverage across countries.
- The ~14% figure from GeoCoded is based on publicly tracked clusters and may overcount or undercount depending on reporting biases.
- China's actual compute is hard to measure due to: stockpiled pre-ban chips (estimated in the hundreds of thousands of A100/H100-equivalents), smuggled chips, domestic alternatives, and classified military systems.
- The rapid pace of US datacenter construction (Stargate, etc.) may be diluting China's share even as China's absolute compute grows.
- "AI-relevant compute" is not precisely defined — different measures (FP32 vs. FP16 vs. INT8; training vs. inference) give different pictures.

What Would Change Our Assessment

- **Upgrade to "on-track":** Updated Epoch AI or CSET estimates placing China at 10–15% of global AI compute by mid-2026
- **Upgrade to "confirmed":** Multiple independent estimates converging on ~12% for China's share at the predicted timeframe
- **Resolve below target:** Comparable installed-stock estimates place China materially below the predicted share. New-deployment flows alone do not establish the stock share.

See Also

- AI 2027 vs Reality — geopolitics category assessment
- Which predictions came true? — full scorecard

Update History

DATE	UPDATE
2026-09-06	Current evidence and assessment explanation reviewed. Clarified measurement scope, source interpretation and limitations.
2026-08-31	SemiAnalysis estimated that about 70% of newly deployed AI data-center watts are going to the US and less than 10% to China. This is an attributed proprietary estimate of deployment flow, not a reproducible measure of China's installed compute stock. Status and confidence remain unchanged.
2026-03-13	Best available data suggests China holds ~14% of tracked AI supercomputer performance (2025 data), roughly consistent with the 12% prediction but with high measurement uncertainty.

Related Predictions

Confirmed **Export controls impact Chinese AI compute** Ongoing

→ On Track **Chinese domestic AI chips 3 years behind US-Taiwan** Mid 2026

Emerging **China nationalizes/centralizes AI research** Mid 2026

PREVIOUS PREDICTION

Best AI agents cost hundreds of dollars per month

NEXT PREDICTION

China nationalizes/centralizes AI research

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